

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

OLYMPIC DUEL

They say politics and sports don't mix, but then they don't know India very well. The latest arena for the joust was the Assam Olympic Association election on September 22, which was taking place after 30 years. In one corner was now Union minister and dormer chief minister **Sarbananda Sonowal**, in the other, current CM **Himanta Biswa Sarma**. While Sonowal got a walkover for the president's post, the lesser seats saw a cage match between the two BJP factions. Things got so spicy that Sarma had to tell some of his MLAs to back off, leading to some awkward last-minute withdrawals. In a quid pro quo, Sarma's brother and IPS officer Sushanta Biswa Sarma got to become vice-president. In the end, both sides split the spoils. In politics, unlike in sports, everyone gets a medal.

Historical Hush



Gujarat historian Dr Rizwan Kadri has stirred up a hornet's nest by writing to **Sonia Gandhi,** former Congress president and keeper of the Nehru-Gandhi family secrets. His request: open up Jawaharlal Nehru's private correspondence with the likes of Jayaprakash Narayan, Edwina Mountbatten and Babu Jagjivan Ram. Specifically, he wants Sonia to return the 51 boxes of letters she took from the Nehru Memorial Museum & Library (now Prime Minister's Museum & Library) in 2008 or, better yet, digitise them for public consumption. "I'm sure it was all done in good faith," he quipped in an interview, while not-so-subtly suggesting a forensic audit to ensure none of the good stuff is missing.

Faith on Track



Photographs: ANI

Bihar CM **Nitish Kumar** has always worn his secular cred as a halo but it seems he's also in step with the rhythm of the devout. On September 22, he wrote a letter to PM Narendra Modi, requesting a Vande Bharat train to connect Ayodhya, the birthplace of Lord Ram in UP, with Sitamarhi in Bihar, where Sita is said to have been born. In the letter, Nitish also said 50 acres had been acquired in Punaura Dham to give the Sitamarhi temple a facelift. Some are even saying if his request is granted, Nitish might just board the Vande Bharat to visit the new Ayodhya temple.





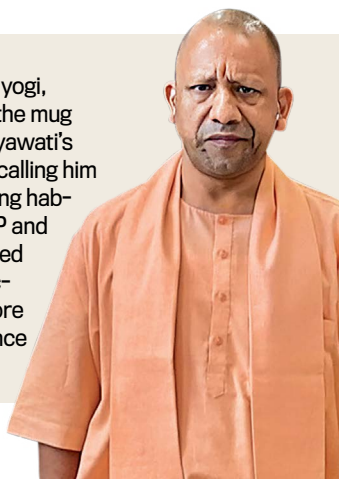
Loose Tongues

Maharashtra's motormouth leaders are it again. While **Sanjay Gaikwad,** MLA of the Eknath Shinde-led Shiv Sena, offered a Rs 11 lakh bounty for Congress leader Rahul Gandhi's chopped-off tongue (apparently for his comments on reservation), BJP Rajya Sabha MP **Anil Bonde** said that Gandhi's tongue should be singed. Aghast leaders of the opposition Maha Vikas Aghadi say the ruling government's leaders need "treatment for mental health".



VERBAL CIRCUS

A war is on in Uttar Pradesh with CM **Yogi Adityanath** and Samajwadi Party (SP) chief **Akhilesh Yadav** trading insults like seasoned pugilists. Yogi, never one to shy from a dramatic metaphor, has called Akhilesh everything from a "dog's tail" to the embodiment of Aurangzeb, reasoning that the Mughal emperor's spirit has entered the SP chief. Not to be outdone, Akhilesh quipped that someone so prone to anger couldn't possibly be a yogi, adding that Yogi's photo looks more like the mug of a mafia boss. Yogi then borrowed Mayawati's famous "Babua" nickname for Akhilesh, calling him out for his alleged mafia ties and late rising habits. He has also been claiming that the SP and Congress were like Bhasmasura—destined to destroy themselves. As the UP byelections approach, the jibes seem to get more vicious. After all, why focus on governance when a good insult can steal the show?



Kaushik Deka with Jumana Shah, Amitabh Srivastava, Ashish Misra and Dhaval S. Kulkarni